

place. Many users can access the same file at the same time and see the changes being made in real time. In addition, all changes are highlighted with indicators in places where authorised users have made revisions. ‘Revision history’ allows you to recover changes made by many people without much difficulty. In addition to these features, many new add-ons were recently introduced: ‘EasyBib’ which helps prepare bibliographies, ‘LucidChart’ for chart making, a track changes option and a vast library of templates that further enhance the functionality of the service and make it more powerful than before.

The service, despite its many offerings, is freely available to general users with a very low monthly subscription cost for companies. The drawbacks of the service have to do with the size limitations of the different types of files created. Document files have a size limit based on characters (1,024,000 cap) irrespective of other features and can’t be larger than 10 MB in size. Similarly the cap on the size of Presentation files is 50 MB.

Layout and design

The layout and design of the Google Drive documents is elegant and simple to begin with, but can be enhanced as required with the use of the many add-ons. The suite operates on an application by application basis with the default Google Drive homepage including the contents of your online storage. New files for any application can be created with the click of the ‘Create’ button on the left panel. The default options for kinds of files you can create are Documents, Spreadsheets, Presentations, Form, Drawings and Folders but more apps can be connected to this dropdown menu as required. Next to the Create button is the ‘Upload’ button with which you can upload a file from your device.

The inset window of the applications takes up most of the main browser viewing space with a coloured icon on the top left that directly opens the Google Drive window. Beside this icon is the name of the file which is usually “Untitled” to begin with. Below the title are the menu options where most of the irregular tools such as add-ons and insert options can be accessed. To the right are the ‘Comments’ and ‘Share’ buttons which control who can view or edit the file as well as look at the comments that have been left. Under this is the main toolbar, which contains all the usual options: Print, Undo/Redo, Paint Format, View Size, Text Style, Font Type/Size, Text Emphasis, Hyperlinks, Insert Comment, Alignment and Line Spacing. There are more tools which are visible on clicking the ‘More’ button on the toolbar. The